Cognitive Homelessness and Maximizing the Unexpected

#planningformistakes #wandering

Philosophers are often concerned with normative questions about how people should decide to act rather than descriptive ones about how they in fact do decide to act. However, normative decision theory cannot always guide us through important decisions (LA Paul 2015a; 2015b; Carter 2026). An opaque decision problem represents the situation of an agent who must decide what to do while being (potentially) uncertain about their own credences. When confronted with personally transformative decisions, we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). This results in us having uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). Therefore, in such cases, it is often easier to be confident that we are in love, when we are in fact in love, than it is to be confident that we are out of love, when we are in fact, not in love. While however, such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in love versus not being in love, they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025). Using Stump 2010, I will argue that a rational decision theory then may be improved by a narrative decision theory of rational choice.

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At the center of this debate is the fact that we do not always have the access to our own states and that many decisions require such access. Sam Carter in his recent paper Planning for Mistakes argues that expected utility theories fail for a class of decision problems called opaque decision problems. However, we might think that a narrative use, e.g., of video games, more directly illustrates the problem of uneven evidence in rational choice theory. I argue that Eleonore Stump develops just such an account. Stump defends a normative theory of rational choice based on narrative-self accounts of personal identity.

She argues that analytic philosophy becomes too narrow and myopic, and excludes "complex, nuanced thought, behavior, relations of persons" (Stump 2010, 23). In this account, she

distances her view from more standard ones in rational choice theory. I contrast her account of narrative thought with a more recent approach in rational choice theory. I argue that a narrative self-account of rational choice might include narrative worlds by using possible worlds logic in place of possible outcomes of expected utility theory. In doing so, I attempt a rational decision formula that is both philosophically rich and illuminating.

Normative decision theory cannot always guide us through important decisions (LA Paul 2015a; 2015b; Carter 2026).

How do we decide what to do? Decision theory proposes an answer. When confronted with personally transformative decisions, we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). Standard normative decision theories cannot always guide us through important decisions (LA Paul 2015a; 2015b; Carter 2026).

We might follow some plan of action, only to find out that the promised outcome is not what we desired after all. Such mistakes in judgment then, stem from failures to recognize our own priorities. We call these opaque decision problems. In other words, they stem from errors in judgment about ourselves.

According to some, whether or not these mistakes are avoidable is an open question. This is because of the plausibility that a key kind of evidence necessary to make correct judgments about ourselves, is not a part of the set of evidence that we have. There are two versions of this case however. In the Rothko case, we would have more reason to question whether one or the other is genuine, assuming that we have each of them before us versus if we only see one, then we would have less reason to question whether there is another one that exists somewhere else.

Therefore we assign equal credence to either possibility, that the one we will bid on is real and the one we do not know about is fake or vice versa. Therefore, we might mistakenly think that upon looking at a counterfeit Rothko, that we desire to bid on the counterfeit Rothko rather than a genuine one.

As such, when confronted with personally transformative decisions, we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000).

Decision theory derives from a long tradition in consequentialism "If, then, there is some end of things doable in action that we wish for because of itself, and the others because of it" [Nichomachean Ethics Bk I, chapter 2]. The implication here is that we should always choose to do that action that we believe will produce the most value. However, "doing whatever will provide the most value" has been criticized [See Lewis, 1981; also see Carter; 2025; Gallow 2021; and Isaacs *et al* 2023; also see Smith 2010.]. It is argued that we do not have access to the world in a way that would allow us to follow through on our plans to maximize value (especially see, Gallow, J. Dmitri. 2021. "Updating for Externalists." *Noûs* 55 (3): 487–516. https://doi.org/10.1111/nous.12307.). Lewis makes a distinction between causal and noncausal approaches to decision making. Noncausal rational choice theories do not make mention of an agent's credences as a factor in their decision making. Orthodox theory, attempts to improve

on decision theory. We should do whatever action has the most expected outcome (Williamson 2000;2011, cf. Srinivasan 2015; LasonenAarnio 2019;2024; Lasonen 2025;2026; Hughes 2021). In other words, decision theory advices that whatever we decide, that when we act, we should act in a way that maximizes our utility (See Brian Skyrms, "Causal Decision Theory," *The Journal of Philosophy* 79, no. 11 (1982): 695–711, https://doi.org/10.2307/2026547.); also see Isaacs and Russell 2023) or perform the action that leads to the outcome with the most expected value.

In following this course of action, we will often make mistakes however. Sometimes it may be because we are uncertain about which acts, out of those available to us, will have the best outcome. There are various reasons why such access is unavailable. Most notably, this kind of evidence is absent when a value state would be experienced by another who is not us. For instance, historically, human beings have often struggled with attributing the mental states they experience, to other human beings. This is because we are rarely certain about the world around us. We are sometimes unaware of other persons who inhabit the world with us, but even more importantly, we are unaware of who these persons may be. For instance, we also struggle with attributing a certain set of values to future versions of ourselves. Therefore, as the objection goes, our imperfect epistemic access to the state of the world imposes limits on our ability to follow Maximize Expected Value" (Carter 2026, 2; cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). Our failure to achieve knowledge of other minds, even our own, is an example of this.

One specific problem in rational choice theory, is the fact that we are often wrong about our priorities. There are many versions of this concern. For instance, let's imagine that on the basis of a coinflip, we will either be shown a genuine or a counterfeit Rothko. If we are shown the counterfeit but not the genuine version, we would be less certain about questioning its authenticity, since we would have no reason to question the authenticity of the fake Rothko having no belief about the real one.

Orthodox decision theory then, recommends acting in a way that maximizes actual or expected value. However our credences with regard to what we value, are opaque and therefore we cannot identify those acts which maximize actual or expected value (Carter 2026; Williamson 2000;2011, cf. Srinivasan 2015; Lasonen-Aarnio 2019;2024; Lasonen 2025;2026; Hughes 2021). Some decisions require such access however. In later sections, I look at recent attempts to save maximize value. I then defend a narrative self account of rational choice. In this section however, I will offer Eleonore Stump's analysis of suffering as an inability to recognize the value of relationship for creatures like us.

What this means is that in the Rothko case, we have no reason to assume that the one we are bidding on is a counterfeit since it is the only one. This shows a different version of the problem, where we have no reason to value a different state of affairs since there is only one. The kind of common mistake that we make, which is important for Stump's thesis, is that an opaque decision problem with respect to decision theory concerns special personal relationships. If we are confronted with two alternative versions of ourselves, then we would have more reason to question whether one, rather than the other, is genuine. Stump argues that narratives give

us reason to question whether one life, rather than any other, is genuine. I think that the best example of this fact can be represented with the following lyric excerpts from the songs "By Yourself" by Tyrone Griffin Jr (Ty Dollar $ign Diggs) and "Rich and Sad" by Austin Richard Post (Post Malone).

Narrative and the Knowledge of Persons

Can an agent always expect to do best by trying to do whatever has the most expected value?

- Orthodox decision theory recommends acting in a way that maximizes expected value,
  - do whatever has the most expected value:
    - i.e., [be] "your own boss"

According to Orthodox decision theory then, agents like us should follow the condition on their credences which is both necessary and sufficient for maximizing expected value (MEV). However, Orthodox decision theory is not always good advice for agents like us. Agents like us are susceptible to error. For agents like us then, who are susceptible to error, there can be situations in which trying to do what has the most expected value (follow MEV), will leave us worse off. Imagine that the following represents: Doing whatever has the most expected value for a given agent

- "Stacked my bread and bought my own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom). I'm my own boss, do it my way (Way)

and then getting it wrong

- "All this stuntin' couldn't satisfy my soul (–oul), Got a hundred big places, but I'm still alone (–one)"

Therefore, while such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in valuing a friendship versus not valuing a friendship. Given our susceptibility to error, it is then important to show which framework works best for evaluating advice. Following Stump, I argue that they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025).

The Nature of Love and Suffering

Using Stump 2010, I will argue that a rational decision theory then may be improved by a narrative decision theory of rational choice. Shame is the connection between moral wrongdoing and some defect of the will. Shame undermines our ability to experience fruitful and deep relationships with others. If I am guilty of stealing from a friend out of necessity, it will be difficult for me to face that individual and our relationship will be strained. If I desire union with the other person, then I will feel shame given that I expect rejection and abandonment by them. Over time however, I may not feel shame any longer. This is because I will no longer desire a relationship with that person.

The remedy may be to repair the will, but sometimes it is not possible for a person's will to change. Notice here that the temptation to steal from the friend came by way of perceived necessity, and therefore outside of my control. This highlights the difference between shame and guilt. I will feel guilt out of my anticipation to be the object of anger or punishment whereas I experience shame when I am anticipating abandonment or rejection. I experience shame out of my desire to be loved by others and conviction that something about me warrants their rejection of me.

The remedy for shame rests in the need of paired processes of justification and sanctification. Importantly, Stump recommends an account of friendship for psychological well-being, where this friendship is grounded in union with God. How do we determine the meaning of concepts like love?

1. There is suffering in the world.
2. There is an omniscient, omnipotent, perfectly good God.
3. There is no morally sufficient reason for an omniscient, omnipotent, perfectly good God to allow suffering in the world.

A problem with this account, is that it rests on theological commitment. However, it in itself is not sufficient for justifying theistic beliefs. But perhaps a better way to understand it is teleological. Here, what is bad about suffering is that it undermines or destroys what the sufferer centrally cares about, whether they realize it or not. * her own flourishing * the desires of her heart * or both

Standard Decision Formulas

Rational choice theory says "choose the act with the highest expected utility." This results in us having uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). While however, such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in love versus not being in love, they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025).

According to rational decision theory, the expected utility of some action

		states	states
		it rains	it does not rain
acts	take umbrella	encumbered, dry	encumbered, dry
acts	leave umbrella	wet	free, dry

The expected utility of an act A (for instance, taking my umbrella)

depends on two features of the problem: * The value of each outcome, measured by a real number called a utility. * The probability of each outcome conditional on the act. * roughly, how likely it is that outcome will occur, on the supposition that the agent chooses act A

$$EU(A) = \sum_{o \in O} P_A(o) \cdot U(o)$$

When confronted with personally transformative decisions, we often have imperfect access to our own epistemic states (Carter, 2026; cf. Jackson 1991; Howard-Snyder 1997; Lenman 2000). Therefore we must often make decisions under conditions of uncertainty.

The expected value of an action at some state s, is the sum of values of the outcomes produced by that action at each state (Carter, 2026, p. 4). We weight the sum of values according to the probability that is assigned to that state from the perspective of that state (Carter, 2026, p. 4). A plan to maximize expected value then recommends, in each state, one of the acts which has optimal expected value at that state.

The way an agent acts depends on the plan they are trying to follow. However, agents like us who are susceptible to error do not always act according to what their plan recommends for the state they are in. Rather we can understand their susceptibility to err in terms of their underlying pattern of dispositions. To represent these dispositions, we need to represent the state an agent is acting as if they are in, what we can call "enriched state spaces".

Where any state $s, [s]$ represents an agent whose act is determined according to what their plan recommends for s and an enriched state, $(s, [s'])$ represents the circumstances of an agent who is in s but whose act is determined according to what their plan recommends for s'. Sets of states in the enriched state space can be thought of as propositions which can tell us about:

1. what the world is like
2. what the agent will act as if the world is like.

Evidence to the contrary is the kind of evidence a person needs that what they desire is not in fact what they desire. A special component of this, is the fact that the evidence we need, evidence to the contrary, is not always available to us.

We can imagine some agent that wants to believe some proposition p about themselves, for instance that they are in love, but for all p, -p is not a part of the agent's evidence. For all the agent knows, desires consistent with not being in love either are, or are not, a part of their evidence set, not accessible to them as evidence. In this case, an agent has evidence consistent with being in love, solely for the reason that evidence consistent with not being in love, is not a part of their evidence set. This is because they may not have access to the necessary counter evidence, that they are, in fact, not in love.

I suspect that the opposite is more common, that we suspect that we are not in love, or no longer in love, solely for the fact that evidence to the contrary, that we are in fact in love, is not a part of our evidence set.

Our errors in judgment are often grounded in these more fundamental errors. Another similar example is that we are not vulnerable to love or that we are invulnerable to love. What this means is that a person believes about themselves, that they are not of the sort who "is mushy" or "terribly affectionate", or that they are an extreme introvert, better off alone, etc. Perhaps this person may believe that they can thrive on short-lived, shallow relationships, or just as commonly, no relationship at all.

This has implications for the kinds of decisions that we make. Examples like the one above illustrate a kind of decision problem in which an agent will not expect to do best by trying to follow a plan to maximize expected value. We make a decision thinking that we desire a given outcome. This can include for instance, that we may experience more joy later on by breaking up with our fiancé now because they demand too much of our time. Our time here being a direct and measurable result that can be quantified, for instance to answer the question "how much did I get done today?" On the other hand however, if we spent the day with a loved one, it might be less obvious how to answer such a question according to quantifiable metrics.

Self 1: "How much did I get done today?"

Self 2: "Not much, I just spent the day with my loved one".

Given our relationship with the other, "Not much" and "I just spent the day with my loved one" seem like contradictory statements. The more likely cause of this contradiction is that it is difficult to quantify one's time spent in this manner, but that is not the same as it is to say that it is difficult to qualify one's time spent in this manner. It may just be that rational choice theory does not have a way to qualify one's time spent even though it has a way to quantify one's time spent.

Often it turns out that the outcome that we thought we desired, was not the outcome that we desired should we achieve it. So while it would have been perhaps possible that the agent could have looked for evidence *that* $\neg p$, ***intentionally-biased inquiry, for instance, th****at maybe I am trauma bonding*, intentionally biased inquiry may be impossible The Externalist's Guide to Fishing for Compliments. However, intentionally-biased inquiry is not impossible. I argue here that cognitive technologies such as religious narratives represents a plausible intentionally-biased inquiry.

Eleonore Stump has argued that love is the interaction of two desires, the first for the good of the beloved and the second, union with the beloved. However, a person often suffers in that they are divided against themselves and so cannot experience desire for the good of the other, or desire for union with another. Desiring the good of, and union with, another places us into a vulnerable state and it is not always clear whether vulnerability in this way is a virtue.

There is a lot of disagreement over what kinds of things we are, whether relationally vulnerable wherein we desire to be with another, or relationally invulnerable where the outcome of not being with another is not a value that we possess, or that it is not a value that overrides other values that we possess. Additionally, *internal integration of the will* would be necessary for love and union with another only if we are relationally vulnerable (Thomas Aquinas, "Adoro

devote," in *The Oxford Book of Medieval Latin Verse,* ed. F.J.E. Raby (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1959), 403-4).

Eleonore Stump defends a two-part Thomistic account of personal identity. A person's first-order desires reflect the *reasons* she has to take something as good whereas their second-order desires reflect the kind of will they want to have. She then contrasts a metaphysics of personal identity which gives a special focus to the rational faculties that a person possesses, where a person's attribution of value is correlated with some particular action in some particular circumstance and a psychology of personal identity where a person's attribution of value is correlated with general reasons of action grounded in their value of a good will.

This results in a response at having uneven evidence in that our confidence towards genuine personal states of value are often higher than our confidence towards illusory personal states of value (Lasonen-Aarnio 2015; Salow 2018; Isaacs and Russell 2023). While however, such decisions may not be practically decided on, being in love versus not being in love, they may be narratively decided on (Rust 2025).